

HASHKAMA



פרשת קרח

ד' תמוז תשפ"ו

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WEEKLY

By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-אמיין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

A gut Shabbos. As any seasoned attendee of our shul knows, if there is a single thing a Yid appreciates more than a thoroughly overcooked piece of potato kugel at the weekly kiddush, it is a spectacular machlokes. In Parshas Korach, we are treated to the ultimate prototype of communal discord. The Torah begins with the words "Vayikach Korach" (Bamidbar 16:1). Rashi (Bamidbar 16:1) quotes the Targum Onkelos that Vayikach means he separated himself to one side. Korach was essentially the first person in recorded history to aggressively demand to speak to the manager. He had immense wealth, prestigious yichus, and a prominent role carrying the Aron, yet he threw it all away because Aharon had a slightly fancier title. The Sefas Emes (Bamidbar 16:1) points out that a genuine machlokes l'sheim shamayim seeks truth, whereas Korach's rebellion was purely about his own ego and kavod. He looked at the spiritual hierarchy and decided the system was flawed simply because he was not situated at the absolute top. This is the tragic flaw of gaavah; it forces a person to isolate themselves, taking their own faction to the side, convinced that everyone else is wrong while they alone hold the objective truth. Korach could not tolerate the idea of a slow, organic growth in his own avodas Hashem, preferring instead to force an immediate, fiery coup that, rather literally, swallowed him whole.

This unnatural desperation for instant gratification brings us directly to the aftermath of the machlokes, where Hashem ends the dispute not with another earthquake, but with a piece of dead wood. The nesim leave their staffs in the Ohel Moed, and the next morning, Aharon's mateh has miraculously sprouted leaves, blossoms, and shkeidim (Bamidbar 17:23). Why specifically shkeidim? Rashi (Bamidbar 17:23), quoting the Midrash Tanchuma (Korach 11), explains that shkeidim are the fastest of all peros to blossom. Aharon's staff demonstrates the opposite of Korach's methodology. Korach tried to artificially accelerate his own prominence through screaming and politics, which resulted in total destruction. Aharon, however, remained entirely passive and silent during the attacks. His mateh proved that when a person is genuinely connected to the Ribbono Shel Olam, their leadership and hashpaah will blossom with incredible speed, yet completely naturally, without requiring any aggressive campaigning. The Chasam Sofer (Toras Moshe, Korach) adds that a dry stick producing fresh shkeidim proves that life and success only stem from ratzon Hashem, not from our own manipulative efforts. Aharon's mateh grew shkeidim — an undeniable neis, even if half our board of directors would complain that they prefer roasted cashews. The shkeidim proved that true koach does not need to be violently seized; it simply blossoms on its own when the time is right, leaving the instigators holding nothing but empty, bitter complaints.

The **practical takeaway** for all of us is to stop aggressively forcing our own shidduchim, parnasah, or seating assignments on the Mizrach wall. When we experience that all too familiar urge to launch a machlokes because we feel slighted or underappreciated, we must remember the dry mateh of Aharon. Instead of constantly demanding immediate recognition and complaining that someone else received the shishi aliyah, we should focus quietly on our own avodas Hashem. If we remain deeply rooted in Torah and genuinely humble, our own unique shkeidim will eventually blossom at the exact moment the Ribbono Shel Olam decides we are ready.

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Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm	מנחה
6:57/8:14 pm	הדלקה (Early/Late)
--- pm	מנחה - קבלת שבת
8:32 pm	שקיעה
3:33/4:12 am	עלות השחר (16.1/72)
5:24 am	נץ החמה
7:15 am	שחרית
Hot Kiddush & Shiur after davening	
8:35/9:11 am	סיור קריאת שמע
10:02/10:27 am	סיור תפילה
12:58 pm	חצות היום
1:36 pm	מנחה גדולה (גר"א)
5:23 pm	מנחה קטנה (גר"א)
6:58 pm	פלג המנחה (גר"א)
--- pm	מנחה
8:32 pm	שקיעה
9:23/9:22 pm	צה"כ ר' משה (8.5/50)
9:24 pm	מעריב (52)
9:32/9:44 pm	צה"כ (60/72)



Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm	מנחה
6:58/8:15 pm	הדלקה (Early/Late)
8:33 pm	שקיעה
7:15 am	שחרית
8:33 pm	שקיעה
9:25 pm	מעריב (52)

Parshah-ly Punny!

Riddle: Why was Korach so entirely confident that his political rebellion against Moshe Rabbeinu would permanently change the landscape of Klal Yisrael?

Answer: He assured all of his followers that it was destined to be a truly groundbreaking movement.



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משל ונמשל ב-Al תאמין? By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Mashal: A gut Shabbos. The Chafetz Chaim (Chafetz Chaim al HaTorah, Korach) offers a geishmake mashal about a wealthy gvir who decided to fund a massive, state-of-the-art pharmacy in his shtetl. He stocked it with the most expensive, imported refuos, purchased gleaming glass vials, and hired a renowned, highly trained rokeach to compound the complex prescriptions. One afternoon, while the rokeach stepped out to daven Mincha, a local am haaretz wandered behind the counter. This fellow, whose primary intellectual achievement was successfully remembering his own name on most days, decided he was perfectly qualified to mix a life-saving elixir. When the horrified gvir caught him pouring random, highly toxic powders into a mortar, the man defended himself with tremendouschutzpah. "Why are you yelling?" he protested. "I have been sweeping the floors of this pharmacy for six months! I breathe the same air as the rokeach, I look at the same bottles, and my broom touches the exact same floorboards! Why should he get all the kavod of mixing the potions while I am relegated to a mop? Are we not all equal citizens of this shtetl?" The gvir looked at him as if he had lost his mind. He explained that while every Yid in the shtetl is equally chashuv in the eyes of Hashem, mixing potent chemicals requires years of rigorous limud and a highly specialized hasagah. Giving an untrained novice the mortar and pestle does not create equality; it creates a cemetery.

Nimshal: The nimshal perfectly illustrates the foundational flaw in the massive machlokes orchestrated against Moshe Rabbeinu. Korach gathered two hundred and fifty prominent men, dressed them in techeiles, and presented a seemingly democratic, modern argument: "Rav lachem ki kol ha'eidah kulam kedoshim uvesocham Hashem umadua tisanu al kehal Hashem" (Bamidbar 16:3). Korach argued that since the entire Klal Yisrael stood at Har Sinai and heard the Anochi, everyone possessed identical spiritual standing. Therefore, why should Moshe and Aharon retain the exclusive leadership roles? The Malbim (Bamidbar 16:3) explains that Korach intentionally conflated intrinsic kedushah with a functional tafkid. It is absolutely true that every Yid possesses a cheilek elokah mimaal and immense inherent holiness. However, intrinsic kedushah does not magically grant someone the authority or the specific spiritual mechanics required to serve as the Kohen Gadol or the Manhig Yisrael. Just as the untrained floor-sweeper in the pharmacy assumed that proximity to medicine equated to medical expertise, Korach assumed that possessing a holy neshamah automatically qualified him to offer the ketores. The ketores, much like a highly volatile prescription, brings immense brachah when administered by the exact right person, but delivers a catastrophic mageifah when handled by unauthorized amateurs. Korach's tragically flawed logic was rooted in a profound misunderstanding of klal dynamics; he refused to accept that a functioning tzibur requires distinct roles, and that not every member of the choir can simultaneously play the tuba.

Practical Takeaway: The Practical Takeaway for our own lives is remarkably relevant, especially for those of us who sit in shul and silently critique the Rav's psak because we once skimmed a footnote in a translated Sefer while waiting for the kiddush to start. We live in a dor where everyone has an internet connection, access to an English database of halacha, and a frankly terrifying amount of unearned self-confidence. It is incredibly easy to adopt the mentality of Korach and insist that kol ha'eidah kulam kedoshim. After all, we all listen to the same shiurim on double speed, we all attended a yeshiva at some point, and we all know how to vigorously argue a completely irrelevant sevara during the Shalosh Seudos. However, we must internalize that true humility means recognizing our own boundaries. Just because a person can successfully navigate the index of a Mishnah Berurah does not mean they are equipped to pasken complex shailos for the tzibur. Hashem designed Klal Yisrael to function with structure, where those who have spent decades toiling in pure limud haTorah are entrusted with the spiritual mortar and pestle. When we try to mix the refuos ourselves out of a misplaced sense of gaavah, we end up causing monumental machlokes and spiritual damage. Instead of demanding equal time behind the steering wheel, our avodah is to support our true talmidei chachamim, respect the mesorah, and perhaps focus our energy on making sure we actually show up to shacharis before Barchu.

GOOD SHABBUS!